

CHAPTER 1 (PART I): INTRODUCTION TO ETHICS

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LEARNING OUTCOMES

- To define and understand the terms of **Ethics and Morality**
- Moral **rules, principles and system**
- The role of **values** in moral system
- Describe the **components** of moral system
- Discussion Stoppers in moral discourse
- Ethical **relativism**

WE LIVE IN COMMUNITIES

Our earth from space → How we view the world??



THE ETHICAL POINT OF VIEW

- Most everyone shares “**core values**”, desiring:
 - Life
 - Happiness
 - Ability to accomplish goals
- Two ways to view world
 - Selfish point of view: consider only own self and its core values
 - Ethical point of view: respect other people and their core values

DEFINING TERMS

■ Society

- Association of people organized under a system of rules
- Rules: advance the good of members over time

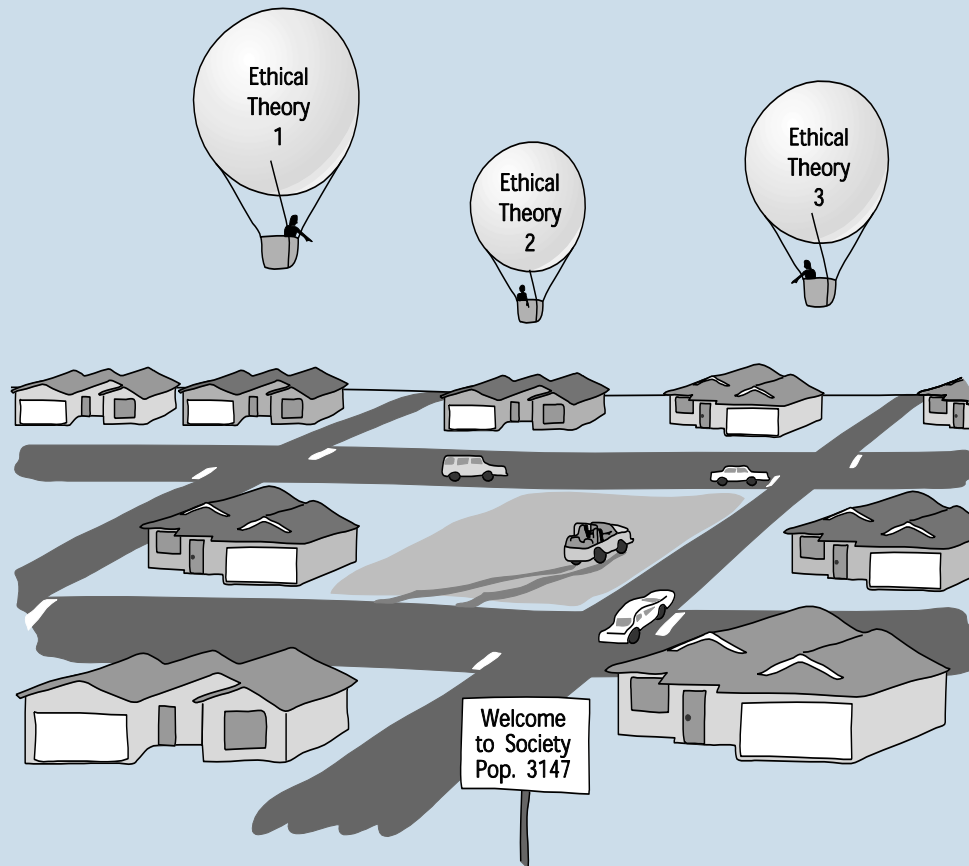
■ Morality

- A society's rules of conduct
- What people ought / ought not to do in various situations

■ Ethics

- Rational examination of morality
- Evaluation of people's behavior

ANALOGY SHOWING DIFFERENCE BETWEEN MORALITY AND ETHICS



Ethics is the philosophical study of morality, a rational examination into people's moral beliefs and behavior. Society is like a town full of people driving cars. Morality is the road network within the town. People ought to keep their cars on the roads. Those who choose to "do ethics" are in balloons floating above the town.

Observer can evaluate individual roads (particular moral guideline) as well as the quality of the entire road network (moral system). The observer can also judge whether individual drivers are staying on the roads (acting morally) or taking shortcuts (acting immorally).

Finally observer can propose and evaluate various ways of constructing road networks (alternative moral systems).

WHY STUDY ETHICS?

- **Ethics: a way to decide the best thing to do**
 - Our society is changing rapidly with latest advances in information technology.
- **New problems accompany new technologies**
 - Iphone4, tablet PC, laptop, www change how we spend our time and interact with others.
 - Some people selfishly exploit new technology for personal gain.
 - Children exposed to pornographic web site
- **New problem (spam, pornographic web site)**
 - Needed to decide which activities are morally “good”, “neutral”, “bad”
 - Existing moral guideline sometimes seem old-fashioned or unclear.
 - So to help us answer these problems
 - **we need to learn to work through these problems ourselves**
→ethics

ETHICS AND MORALITY

- The term *Ethics* is derived from *Ethos* (Greek), and *Morality* from *Mores* (Latin).
 - Both terms translate roughly into notions affecting “custom,” “habit,” and “behavior.”
- Ethics is defined as *the study of morality which* raises two questions:
 - (a) What is *morality*?
 - (b) What is *the study of morality*?

ETHICS DEFINITION

- **Study of morality**
- Study about moral beliefs and **rules** about right and wrong
- Practice of making a **principle** of choice between right and wrong
- The rules of conduct recognized in respect to a particular class of human actions
- The **philosophical examination study of morality**, a rational into people moral beliefs and behavior

ETHICS DEFINITION

- We have been taught that a certain kind of behavior, the right kind, is acceptable; the wrong kind is unacceptable
- As responsible human: make a **right** choice and do **right** things



WHAT IS MORALITY?

- **Morality** can be defined as:
*a system of **rules** for guiding human conduct, and **principles** for evaluating those rules.*

Two points are worth noting in this definition:

- (i) morality is a **system**;
 - (ii) it is a system comprised of moral **rules** and **principles**.
- Moral rules can be understood as "**rules of conduct**," which are very similar to "**policies**."

RULES OF CONDUCT AS “POLICIES”

- James Moor (2004) notes that *policies* can range from formal laws to informal, implicit guidelines for actions.
- Moor suggests that every **act** can be viewed as an instance of a **policy**.
- There are two kinds of **rules of conduct**:
 - 1) **Directives** for guiding our conduct as individuals (at the micro-level)
 - 2) **Social Policies** framed at the macro-level.

DIRECTIVES

- **Directives** are rules of conduct that guide our actions, and thus **direct** us to behave in certain ways.
- Rules such as:
 - "Do not steal"
 - "Do not harm others"are both examples of rules of conduct that direct us in our individual moral choices at the "**micro-ethical**" level (i.e., the level of individual behavior).

SOCIAL POLICIES

- Some rules of conduct guide our actions at the "**macro-ethical**" level by helping us frame ***social policies***.
- Rules such as:
 - "Proprietary software should not be copied"
 - "Software that can be used to invade the privacy of users should not be developed"are examples of rules of conduct that arise out of our social policies.
- Notice the correlation between directives and social policies (e.g., rules involving stealing).

PRINCIPLES

- The rules of conduct in a moral system are **evaluated** by way of standards called *principles*.
- For example, the principle of "**social utility**" (i.e., promoting the greatest good for the greatest number) can be used to evaluate a social policy such as
 - "Proprietary software should not be copied without permission."

PRINCIPLES (CONTINUED)

- In the previous example, the principle of *social-utility* functioned as a kind of "**litmus test**" for determining whether the policy pertaining to proprietary software could be justified on moral grounds.
- A policy, X, could be justified (on utilitarian grounds) by showing that following Policy X (i.e., not allowing the unauthorized copying of software) would produce more overall social utility (greater good for society).

BASIC COMPONENTS OF A MORAL SYSTEM

Moral System

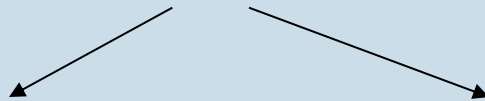
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graph TD; MS[Moral System] --> RC[Rules of Conduct]; MS --> PE[Principles of Evaluation]; RC --> T2[two types]; T2 --> RL[Rules for guiding the actions of individuals<br/>(micro-level ethical rules)]; T2 --> RS[Rules for establishing social policies<br/>(macro-level ethical rules)]; RL --> RL_Exp[Examples include directives such as:<br/>"Do not steal" and<br/>"Do not harm others."]; RS --> RS_Exp[Examples include social policies such as:<br/>"Software should be protected" and<br/>"Privacy should be respected."]; PE --> PE_Exp[Examples include principles such as<br/>of social utility and justice as fairness];
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Rules of Conduct

(Action-guiding rules, in the form of either *directives* or social *policies*)



two types



Rules for guiding the actions of *individuals* (**micro-level ethical rules**)



Examples include directives such as: "Do not steal" and "Do not harm others."

Rules for establishing *social policies* (**macro-level ethical rules**)



Examples include social policies such as: "Software should be protected" and "Privacy should be respected."

Principles of Evaluation

(Evaluative standards used to justify rules of conduct)



Examples include principles such as of social utility and justice as fairness

BERNARD GERT'S SCHEME OF A *MORAL SYSTEM*

- According to Bernard Gert (2005), **morality** is a *system* that is:
 - like a **game**, but more like an **informal** game (e.g., a game of cards)
 - **public** (open and accessible to all)
 - **rational** (open to reason)
 - **impartial** (e.g., Gert's "blindfold of justice").

TABLE 1-1: FOUR FEATURES OF GERT'S MORAL SYSTEM

Public

The rules are known to all of the members.

Informal

The rules are informal, not like formal laws in a legal system.

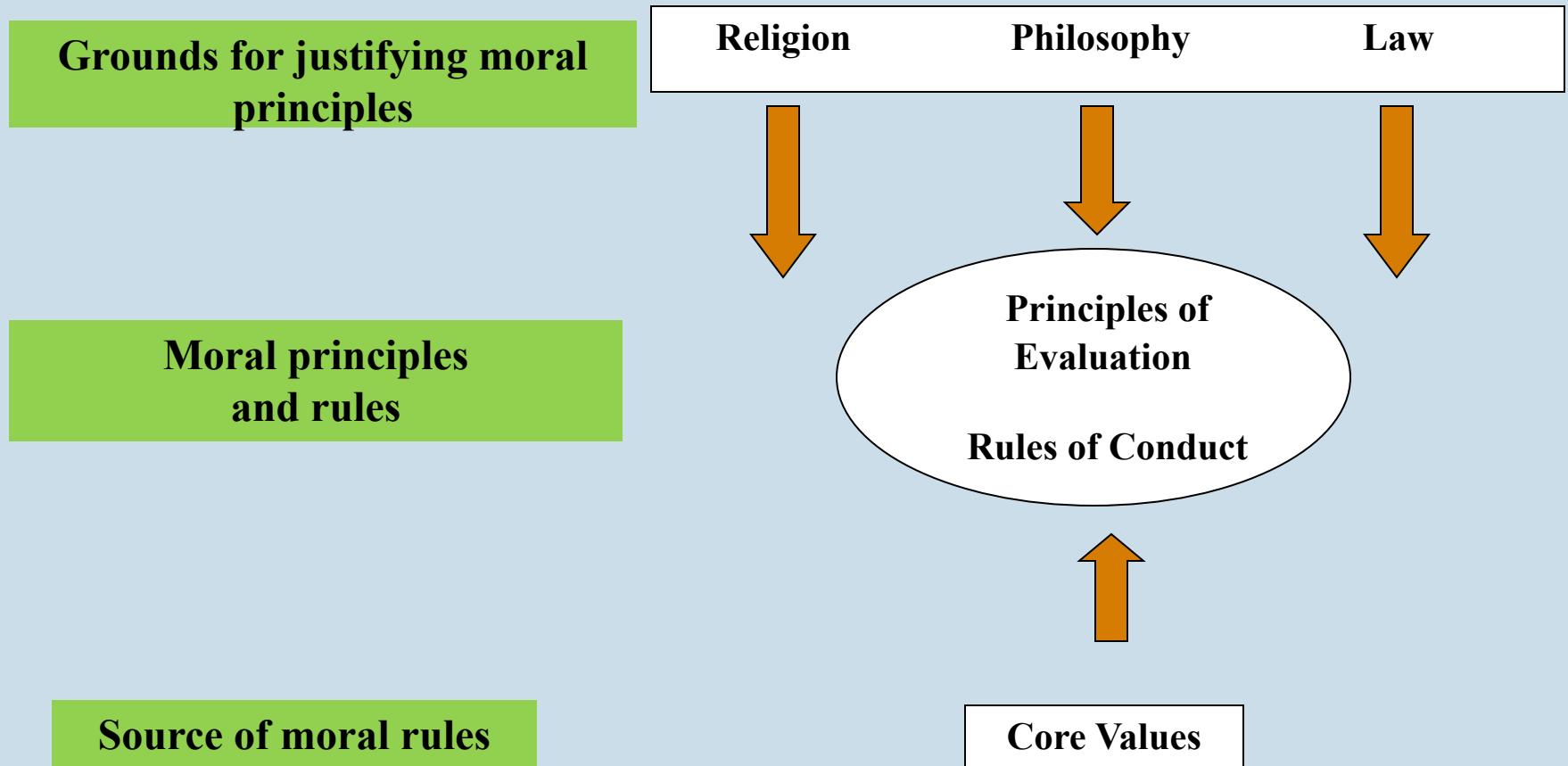
Rational

The system is based on principles of logical reason accessible to all its members.

Impartial

The system is not partial to any one group or individual.

FIGURE 1-2: COMPONENTS OF A MORAL SYSTEM



THE ROLE OF VALUES IN A MORAL SYSTEM

- The term **value** comes from the Latin *valere*, which translates roughly into **having worth** or **being of worth** (Pojman, 2006).
- Values can be viewed as objects of our **desires** or **interests**.
 - Examples of values include very general notions such happiness, love, freedom, etc.
- Moral rules are ultimately derived from a society's system of values.

INTRINSIC VS. INSTRUMENTAL VALUES

- Philosophers distinguish between two types of values: *intrinsic* and *instrumental* values.
- Any value that serves some further end or good is called an *instrumental* value because it is tied to some external standard.
 - Automobiles, computers, and money are goods that have instrumental value.
- Values such as life and happiness are *intrinsic* because they are valued for their own sake.

CORE VALUES

- Another approach to cataloguing values is to distinguish **core values**, some of which may or may not also be **intrinsic** values, from other kinds of values.
- Moor (2004) argues that values such as life, happiness, and autonomy are core values because they are **basic** to a society's thriving and perhaps even to a society's survival.
- Not all core values are also *moral* values.

MORAL VS. NON-MORAL VALUES

- Morals and values are not necessarily identical.
- **Values** can be either moral or non-moral.
- Reason informs us that it is in our interest to develop values that promote our own survival, happiness, and flourishing as individuals.
- When used to further only our own self-interests, these values are not necessarily moral values.

MORAL VALUES

- Once we bring in the notion of *impartiality*, we begin to take the "moral point of view."
- When we frame the rules of conduct in a moral system, we articulate a system of values having to do with notions such as autonomy, fairness, justice, etc., which are moral values.
- Our basic moral values are derived from **core non-moral values**.

FIGURE 1-3: COMPONENTS OF A MORAL SYSTEM: AN EXPANDED VIEW

Grounds for Justifying the Moral Principles

Religion
(Obedience to Divine Command)

Philosophical Ethics
(Ethical Theory and Logical Argumentation)

Law
(Obedience to a legal system)

Moral Principles

Moral Principles

Principles such as social utility, duty, obligation, etc. are used as standards to evaluate and justify rules of conduct.

Source of the Moral rules

Rules of Conduct

Moral rules are derived from basic moral values (macro-level rules or *policies* such as "protect privacy"; micro-level rules or *directives* such as "do not cheat").

Basic Moral Values

Moral values are derived from core non-moral values by using the notion of *impartiality*. (Examples include autonomy and respect for persons.)

Core Non-Moral Values

Non-moral values originate from desires and typically involve *rational* self interests. (Examples include: survival, security, pleasure, etc.)

THREE SCHEMES FOR GROUNDING THE EVALUATIVE RULES IN A MORAL SYSTEM

- The principles are grounded in one of three different kinds of schemes:
 - **Religion;**
 - **Law;**
 - **Philosophical Ethics.**
- Consider how a particular moral principle can be justified from the vantage-points of each scheme.
 - E.g., consider the rule of conduct: “Do not steal.”

APPROACH #1: GROUNDING MORAL PRINCIPLES IN A RELIGIOUS SYSTEM

- Consider the following rationale for why stealing is morally wrong:

Stealing is wrong because it offends God or because it violates one of God's (Ten) Commandments.

- From the point of view of institutionalized religion, stealing is wrong because of it offends God or because it violates the commands of a supreme authority.

APPROACH #2: GROUNDING MORAL PRINCIPLES IN A LEGAL SYSTEM

An alternative rationale would be:

Stealing is wrong because it violates the law.

- Here the grounds for determining why stealing is wrong are not tied to religion.
- If stealing violates a law in a particular nation or jurisdiction, then the act of stealing can be declared to be wrong independent of any religious beliefs that one may or may not happen to have.

APPROACH #3: GROUNDING MORAL PRINCIPLES IN A PHILOSOPHICAL SYSTEM OF ETHICS

- A third way of approaching the question is:

Stealing is wrong because it is wrong (independent of any form of external authority or any external sanctions).

- On this view, the moral "rightness" or "wrongness" of stealing is not grounded in some external authoritative source.
- It does not appeal to an external authority, either theological or legal, for justification.

APPROACH # 3 CONTINUED

- Many philosophers and ethicists have argued that, independent of either supernatural or legal authorities, *reason* alone is sufficient to show that stealing is wrong.
- They argue that *reason* can inform us that there is something either in the act of stealing itself, or in the *consequences* that result from this kind of act, that makes stealing morally wrong.

APPROACH # 3 CONTINUED

- In the case of both law and religion, specific sanctions against stealing exists in the form of punishment.
- In the case of (philosophical) ethics, the only sanction would be in the form of social **disapprobation** (disapproval) and possibly social **ostracism**.
 - E.g., there is no punishment in a formal sense.
- External conditions or factors, in the form of sanctions, are irrelevant.

THE METHOD OF PHILOSOPHICAL ETHICS

- The method philosophers use to analyze moral issues is **normative**, in contrast to the **descriptive** method that is used by social scientists.
- Sociological and anthropological studies are descriptive because they describe or report how people in various cultures and groups behave with respect to the rules of a moral system.
- For example, a sociologist might report that people who live in nations along the Pacific Rim believe that it is morally permissible to make copies of proprietary software for personal use.

PHILOSOPHICAL STUDIES VS. SCIENTIFIC STUDIES

- Philosophical studies and scientific studies are **similar** in that both require that a **consistent methodological scheme** be used to verify **hypotheses and theories**.
 - These verification schemes must satisfy criteria of *rationality* and *objectivity* (or *impartiality*).
- Philosophical studies also **differ** from scientific studies because scientists typically **conduct experiments** in a laboratory to confirm or refute a hypothesis.
 - Philosophers have **no physical laboratory** to test ethical theories and claims; they evaluate a claim or thesis by testing it against the rules of **logical argumentation** (see Chapter 3).

ETHICISTS VS. MORALISTS

- Ethicists study morality from the perspective of philosophical methodology and they
 - appeal to logical arguments to justify their positions.
- Moralists often claim to have all of the answers regarding morality, and often they
 - exhibit characteristics that have been described as "preachy" and "judgmental."
- Some moralists may have a particular moral agenda to advance.

ETHICISTS VS. MORALISTS (CONTINUED)

- Ethicists, in using the philosophical method to analyze and investigate moral issues, must **remain open** to different sides of a dispute.
- An ethicist's primary focus is on **the study of morality** and the **application of theories**.
- Ethicists approach the study of moral issues and controversies by way of standards that are both **rational** (based on logic) and **impartial** (open to others to verify).

DISCUSSION STOPPERS AS "ROADBLOCKS" TO MORAL DISCOURSE

- **Discussion stoppers** can be articulated in terms of the following four questions:
 - 1. *People disagree about morality; so how can we reach agreement on moral issues?*
 - 2. *Who am I/Who are we to judge others and to impose my/our values on others?*
 - 3. *Isn't morality simply a private matter?*
 - 4. *Isn't morality simply a matter that different cultures and groups should determine for themselves?*

DISCUSSION STOPPER # 1: PEOPLE DISAGREE ON SOLUTIONS TO MORAL ISSUES

- **People who hold this view** fail to recognize:
 - (i) **Experts in other fields of study**, such as science and math., also disagree on what the correct answers to certain questions are.
 - (ii) There is **common agreement** about answers to some moral questions.
 - (iii) **People do not always distinguish** between "disagreements about factual matters" and "disagreements on general principles" in disputes involving morality.

DISCUSSION STOPPER # 2: WHO AM I TO JUDGE OTHERS?

- We need to distinguish between:
 - (a) “persons **making judgments**” and “persons **being judgmental**,” and
 - (b) “judgments involving **condemnations**” vs. “judgments involving **evaluations**.”
- Also, we are sometimes required to make judgments about others.

DISCUSSION STOPPER # 3: ETHICS IS SIMPLY A PRIVATE MATTER

- Many people assume that morality is essentially personal in nature and that morality must therefore be simply a private matter.
- “Private morality” is essentially an oxymoron or contradictory notion.
- Morality is a *public* phenomenon (Gert).

DISCUSSION STOPPER # 4: MORALITY IS SIMPLY A MATTER FOR INDIVIDUAL CULTURES TO DECIDE

- According to this view, a moral system is dependent on, or relative to, a particular culture or group.
- There are some very serious problems with this view, which is called.
- It is useful to distinguish between *ethical relativism* and two positions involving relativism:
 - *cultural relativism*
 - *moral relativism.*

DISCUSSION STOPPER #4

CONTINUED - *CULTURAL RELATIVISM*

- At the base of cultural relativism is the following assumption:

(A) *Different cultures have different belief systems about what constitutes morally right and wrong behavior.*

- Note that (A) is essentially a *descriptive* thesis.

CULTURAL RELATIVISM CONTINUED

- Although (A) -- *the assumption that different groups have different conceptions about what is morally right and morally wrong behavior* -- is widely accepted, some social scientists believe that the reported differences between cultures have been greatly exaggerated.
- Other social scientists have suggested that all cultures may recognize some universal core moral values.

CULTURAL RELATIVISM (CONTINUED)

- Even if cultural relativism (Thesis A) is true, we can ask if (A) logically implies the claim

(B) No universal standard of morality is possible (because what is morally right or wrong can only be determined only by some culture or group).
- Note that (B), unlike (A), is a *normative* thesis.
- Also note that to move from (A) to (B) is to move from *cultural* relativism to *moral* relativism.

MORAL RELATIVISM

- Moral relativists make a questionable move:
Premise: Different cultures have different beliefs about what is right and wrong
Conclusion: No universal standard of morality is possible.
- Many moral relativists also seem to suggest that, in matters of morality, “anything goes.”
- But the moral relativist’s view is essentially incoherent and inconsistent.

MORAL RELATIVISM (CONTINUED)

- Does it follow that individuals who reside outside a particular culture, X, can never make any judgments about the behavior of those who live within X?
- Consider that in many tribes in West Africa a ritual of female circumcision is still practiced.
 - While this practice has been a tradition for many generations, some females living in tribes that still perform this ritual on teenage girls have objected.
 - Many people who live outside these cultures condemn this practice. Are they wrong to do so?

MORAL RELATIVISM (CONTINUED)

- Assume that the majority of residents in Culture X approve of female circumcision.
- Would it be inappropriate for those who lived outside of West Africa to claim that the treatment of young women in those tribes is morally wrong, simply because they are not members of Culture X?
- If we embrace that view, wouldn't it follow that a culture can devise any moral scheme it wishes as long as the majority approve it?

MORAL OBJECTIVISM VS. MORAL ABSOLUTISM

- We can reject moral relativism without necessarily embracing moral absolutism.
- **Moral absolutism** claims that there is only one uniquely correct answer to every moral problem.
- **Moral objectivism** asserts that (for at least some moral issues) there can be more than one acceptable answer, so long as rational standards apply.
 - While there may not be only one uniquely correct answer to every moral problem, there are can be many incorrect answers to problems.
 - Moral objectivism avoids the relativist's "anything goes" view

TABLE SUMMARY OF LOGICAL FLAWS IN THE DISCUSSION STOPPERS

Stopper #1

People disagree on solutions to moral issues.

1. Fails to recognize that experts in many areas disagree on key issues in their fields.
2. Fails to recognize that there are many moral issues on which people agree.
3. Fails to distinguish between disagreements about principles and disagreements about facts.

Stopper #2

Who am I to judge others?

1. Fails to distinguish between the act of judging and being a judgmental person.
2. Fails to distinguish between judging as condemning and judging as evaluating.
3. Fails to recognize that sometimes we are required to make judgments

Stopper #3

Ethics is imply a private matter.

1. Fails to recognize that morality is essentially a public system.
2. Fails to note that personally-based morality can cause major harm to others.
3. Confuses moral choices with individual or personal preferences.

Stopper #4

Morality is simply a matter for individual cultures to decide.

1. Fails to distinguish between descriptive and normative claims about morality.
2. Assumes that people can never reach common agreement on some moral principles.
3. Assumes that a system is moral because a majority in a culture decides it is moral.